

SUCCESS MANTRA

Maiya firmly believes in thinking big and dreaming even bigger

role MODEL

Father Yajnanarayana. He used to mention the ingredients and calories in every dish he made.

biggest OBSTACLE

Converting a conservative family-run enterprise into an international business



ABHISHEK SCARIA

SADANANDA
MAIYA

60, FOOD SPECIALIST
MD, M T R FOODS
TURNOVER IN 1971 Rs 10 lakh
CURRENT TURNOVER Rs 195 crore

THE SPICE ROUTE

It is 7 a.m. on a misty morning but there's already a crowd jostling to enter Mavalli Tiffin Room (better known as MTR), an insignificant-looking but legendary restaurant in Bangalore. It is to this restaurant, founded in 1924 by his father Parampalli Yajnanarayana Maiya that Sadananda Maiya came for work as an apprentice in the kitchen in 1968. "I was still at BMS College of Engineering in Bangalore then. I got fully involved in the business only in 1971," he smiles. This was the legendary family-run business that had invented the rava idli during the second World War due to shortage of rice.

Transforming a family-run unit to an internationally acknowledged company in the processed food segment was Sadananda's contribution. "During the Emergency, when price control was imposed on restaurants, we decided to shut it rather than compromise on quality,"

recalls Sadananda, who still lives in a simple upper middle-class locality in Bangalore and prefers driving a mid-range car rather than a high-end one. The family then had to look for alternative means to pay the salaries of 40 people, which they did by selling ready-made mixes. Thus was planted the seed of a colossal ready-to-eat business.

In 2007, Sadananda sold his stake in the processed food business to Norwegian food giant Orkla for a whopping Rs 350 crore, retaining just the pickle and ice cream section. The agreement required him to continue as MD for a year, and be the executive and advisory director for life. "I'm trying to put a system in place, before I take a complete break," laughs the 60-year-old Sadananda. But with a restaurant and pickle business calling for his attention, it doesn't look as if he will get his wish soon. *by Nirmala Ravindran*